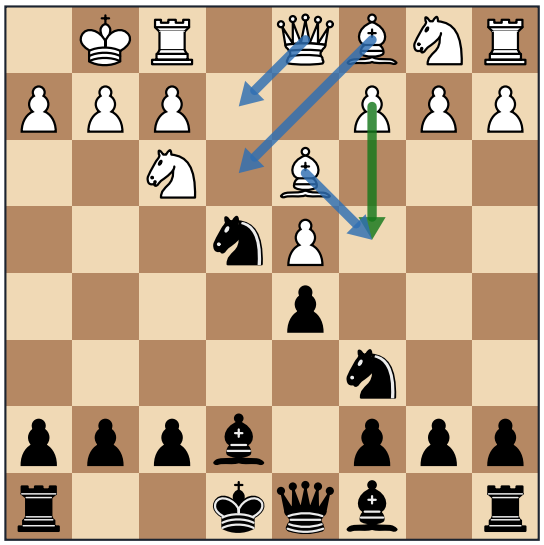
Petrov's Defense

ECO C42-C43 | 50 named lines | Open games (1.e4 e5)

In one sentence: Classical open-game theory: rapid development, central tension and king safety decide the game.

Memory pattern: Knights, bishops, castle, then open the center when ahead in development.



Main line: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 d5 6.Bd3 Nc6 7.O-O Be7

Key ideas

1. Develop knights before bishops and castle early.
2. Fight for the center with d4 or ...d5 at the right moment.
3. Use gambit ideas (Scotch, King's Gambit, Vienna) only when you know the follow-up tactics.
4. Avoid pawn grabs that cost tempi; watch f7/f2 weaknesses.
5. Trade pieces when ahead; keep tension when your pieces are more active.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.48** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best: c4.

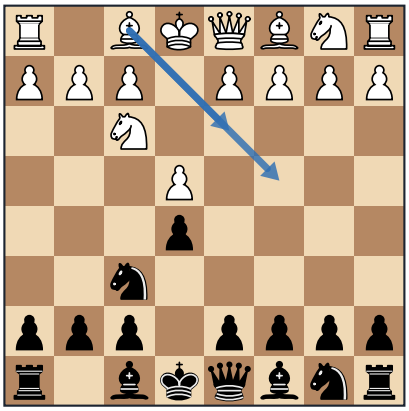
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Open centre: lines open early, so development and king safety dominate. Structures range from open centres to gambit positions.
2. Where does my king go?	Castle early; do not leave the king in the center when lines open.
3. Best minor pieces?	Develop knights then bishops; fight for the center and the f7/f2 squares.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Complete development, castle, then open the center or attack the weak point.
5. What does my opponent want?	The side with the initiative wants to open lines; the defender wants to neutralize with ...d5 or ...Nf6.

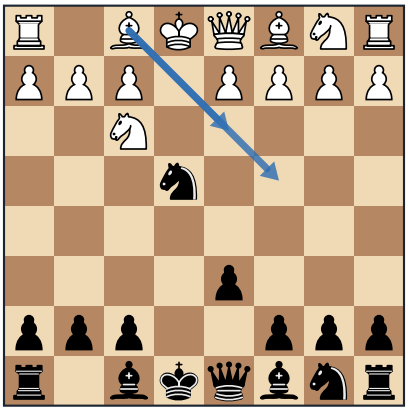
The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 d5 6.Bd3 Nc6 7.O-O Be7

Move	Why it is played
1. e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... e5	Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
2... Nf6	Counter e4. Develops the knight to f6.
3. Nxe5	Captures on e5 to trade or win material.
3... d6	Support e5. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4. Nf3	Repositions the knight to a more active square.
4... Nxe4	Captures on e4 to trade or win material.
5. d4	Central break. Occupies the center with a pawn.
5... d5	Free the position. Occupies the center with a pawn.
6. Bd3	Develops the bishop to d3.
6... Nc6	Develops the knight to c6.
7. O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
7... Be7	Develops the bishop to e7.



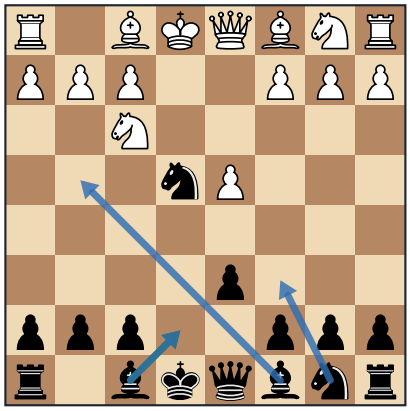
After 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6



After 6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

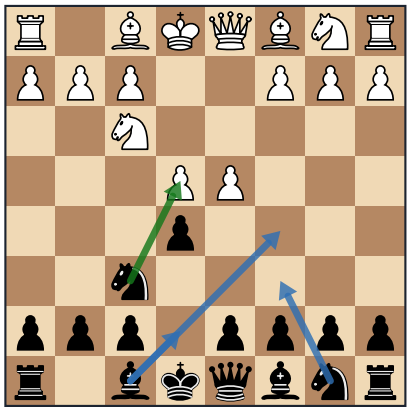


Position after the line

Classical Attack C42 | 16 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4`

Stockfish: **+0.41** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Be7.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Chigorin Variation, Marshall Variation, Berger Variation, Closed Variation

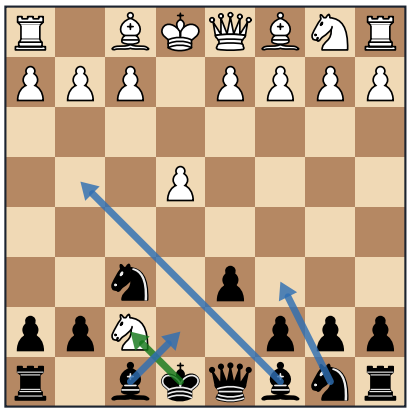


Position after the line

Modern Attack C43 | 10 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.d4`

Stockfish: **+0.42** (slightly better for White, depth 18). Best next move: Nxe4.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Bardeleben Variation, Center Attack, Center Variation, Murrey Variation



Position after the line

Cochrane Gambit C42 | 3 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nxf7`

Stockfish: **-0.74** (slightly better for Black, depth 16). Best next move: Kxf7.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Bishop Check Line, Center Variation

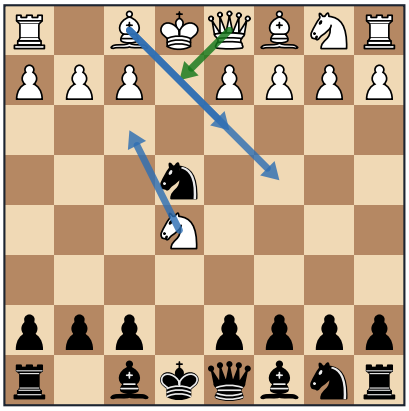


Position after the line

Stafford Gambit Accepted C42 | 3 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 Nc6 4.Nxc6 dxc6`

Stockfish: **+1.83** (clearly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: d3.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)

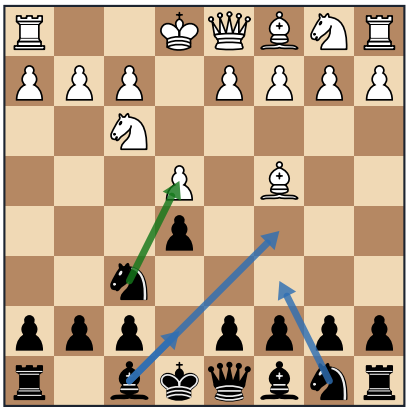


Position after the line

Damiano Variation C42 | 2 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 Nxe4`

Stockfish: **+0.70** (slightly better for White, depth 18). Best next move: Qe2.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)
Sub-variations: Kholmov Gambit



Position after the line

Italian Variation C42 | 1 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Bc4`

Stockfish: **-0.33** (slightly better for Black, depth 15). Best next move: Nxe4.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)

Detailed repertoire notes

Petroff Defense (C42-C43, Black)

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 d5 6.Bd3 Nc6 7.O-O Be7 8.c4 Nb4 9.Be2 O-O 10.Nc3 Bf5 11.a3 Nxc3 12.bxc3 Nc6`

Idea: Counterattack e4 immediately; reach a symmetrical structure where White has little to attack.

Structure: Symmetrical pawn structure; the game is about piece activity and small endgame edges.

Pieces: Knights e4/f6, bishops e7/f5, queen d7/e8, rooks e8/d8.

Plan: Complete development, hit the center with ...c5 or ...Nb4, and look for equalizing exchanges.

King: Castle by move 7 and keep it simple. **Opponent:** Nc3 and Bd3 pressure for a small endgame edge; avoid a Qd2/Bh6 attack.

Watch out: White can play for a small edge with Nc3 and h3; avoid passivity.

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Count your developed pieces versus your opponent's every move. If you are ahead, open the position; if behind, keep it closed or trade.

Why play it

Classical open-game theory: rapid development, central tension and king safety decide the game.

Typical mistakes

- Early queen sorties that lose time.
- Leaving the king in the center when lines are open.
- Grabbing a pawn and falling behind in development.

Typical tactics and traps

- Fried Liver, Legal's Mate and similar f7/f2 tactics.
- Scholar's-style Qh5/Bc4 attacks on f7 if Black ignores them.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Open games reward activity; simplified endings depend on pawn structure and piece activity.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Petrov's Defense (all lines)** C42
  `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6`
  - **Italian Variation** C42
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Bc4`
  - **Modern Attack** C43
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.d4`
    - **Symmetrical Variation** C43
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.d4 -> 3...d5`
    - **Center Variation** C43
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.d4 -> 3...Nxe4 4.Bd3`
    - **Murrey Variation** C43
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.d4 -> 3...Nxe4 4.Bd3 Nc6`
    - **Center Attack** C43
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.e5 Ne4 5.Qxd4`
    - **Steinitz Variation** C43
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.e5 Ne4 5.Qe2`
    - **Tal Gambit** C43
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.e5 Ne4 5.Bb5`
    - **Bardeleben Variation** C43
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.e5 Ne4 5.Qe2 Nc5 6.Nxd4 Nc6`
    - **Trifunovic Variation** C43
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.d4 -> 3...Nxe4 4.Bd3 d5 5.Nxe5 Bd6 6.O-O O-O 7.c4 Bxe5`
  - **Three Knights Game** C42
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Nc3`
  - **Damiano Variation** C42
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Nxe5 Nxe4`
    - **Kholmov Gambit** C42
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 Nxe4 -> 4.Qe2 Qe7`
  - **Stafford Gambit** C42
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Nxe5 Nc6`
  - **Cochrane Gambit** C42
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nxf7`
    - **Bishop Check Line** C42
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nxf7 -> 4...Kxf7 5.Bc4`
    - **Center Variation** C42
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nxf7 -> 4...Kxf7 5.d4`
  - **Karklins-Martinovsky Variation** C42
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nd3`
  - **Moody Gambit** C42
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Qe2 Nc6 4.d4`
  - **Paulsen Attack** C42
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nc4`
  - **Stafford Gambit Accepted** C42
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Nxe5 Nc6 4.Nxc6 dxc6`
  - **Classical Attack** C42
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4`
    - **Closed Variation** C42
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 -> 5...Nf6`
    - **Marshall Variation** C42
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 -> 5...d5 6.Bd3 Bd6`
      - **Chinese Gambit** C42
        `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 d5 6.Bd3 Bd6 -> 7.O-O O-O 8.c4 c6 9.Re1 Bg4`
    - **Mason-Showalter Variation** C42
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 -> 5...d5 6.Bd3 Nc6`
    - **Mason Variation** C42
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 -> 5...d5 6.Bd3 Be7 7.O-O O-O`
    - **Chigorin Variation** C42
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 -> 5...d5 6.Bd3 Be7 7.O-O Nc6 8.Re1`

- **Browne Attack** C42
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 d5 6.Bd3 Nc6 7.O-O Be7 8.c4 Nb4 9.cxd5
- **Main Line** C42
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 d5 6.Bd3 Nc6 7.O-O Be7 8.c4 Nb4 9.Be2
- **Jaenisch Variation** C42
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 -> 5...d5 6.Bd3 Nc6 7.O-O Be7 8.c4
- **Staunton Variation** C42
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 -> 5...d5 6.Bd3 Bd6 7.O-O O-O 8.c4 c6
- **Tarrasch Variation** C42
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 -> 5...d5 6.Bd3 Bd6 7.O-O O-O 8.c4 Bg4
- **Berger Variation** C42
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 -> 5...d5 6.Bd3 Be7 7.O-O Nc6 8.Re1 Bg4 9.c3 f5 10.Nbd2
- **Krause Variation** C42
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 -> 5...d5 6.Bd3 Nc6 7.O-O Be7 8.Re1 Bg4 9.c3 f5 10.c4
- **Marshall Trap** C42
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 -> 5...d5 6.Bd3 Bd6 7.O-O O-O 8.c4 Bg4 9.cxd5 f5 10.Re1 Bxh2
- **Maróczy Variation** C42
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 -> 5...d5 6.Bd3 Be7 7.O-O Nc6 8.Re1 Bg4 9.c3 f5 10.c4 Bh4
- **Cozio Attack** C42
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.Qe2
- **French Attack** C42
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d3
- **Kaufmann Attack** C42
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.c4
- **Millennium Attack** C42
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.Bd3
- **Nimzowitsch Attack** C42
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.Nc3

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 d6 4.Nf3 Nxe4 5.d4 d5
```

Plan chain

White	Nf3 -> Nc3 -> d4 -> Bc4 -> Bd3
Black	Nc6 -> Nf6 -> d5 -> Be7 -> Bc5

Three rules to remember

1. Knights, bishops, castle, then open the center when ahead in development.
2. Complete development, castle, then open the center or attack the weak point.
3. The side with the initiative wants to open lines; the defender wants to neutralize with ...d5 or ...Nf6.

Pawn structure in one line

Open centre: lines open early, so development and king safety dominate. Structures range from open centres to gambit positions.